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Geneva, October 1991

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I. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

In a world of more people, who are mostly poorer and geographically more concentrated, in a world of diminishing resources and deteriorating environment, the evidence and likelihood of an **increasing toll** from disasters for some years to come is recognized universally.

Efforts to resist and eventually to reverse this trend have, in recent years been referred to as **disaster management**. Communities, organizations and governments practice and promote it in various forms, with uneven success the world over.

This broad discipline has two main traits: its **cross-sectoral character**, and its **thematic unity**. Disaster management spans many sectors. Its best results come from being practiced in a continuum of related steps: prevention, preparedness, relief, rehabilitation, reconstruction.

The differences in destructiveness between hazardous events of comparable magnitudes in different but comparable environments shows that knowledge, techniques, procedures, and technologies do exist to "reduce" the impact of disasters at reasonable cost. The General Assembly's declaration of the **International Decade for Natural Disaster Reduction (IDNDR)** is an important statement of this fact.

As a world system oriented towards development and providing technical, social, economic and humanitarian assistance, and also as a political body, the **United Nations System** is involved in disaster management. It provides technical assistance in prevention and preparedness. It undertakes mobilization, coordination, and provision of international relief supplies and services and of reconstruction/rehabilitation aid and expertise.

UNDRO's establishment in 1971 was the United Nations' first structural manifestation of its increasing involvement in disaster management. There have since been established a number of specific disaster/emergency entities and programmes in the specialized agencies and regional commissions. UNDRO remains the only United Nations Office whose mandate relates **exclusively to disaster management**.

The United Nations' role in responding to natural disasters and emergencies, whether as a simple participant in the international response, or as lead world body, requires that, in addition to the provision of emergency assistance, a number of **core tasks** need to be performed. These relate chiefly to expert guidance, organization, coordination and to the management of information.

The fractured, sometimes overlapping nature of the System's disaster management capability shows up in emergency response. Ad hoc arrangements tend to be resorted to for "complex" emergencies and there are **recurrent re-inventions** of the disaster management/disaster response "wheel". These show the difficulties which the UN System has in meeting both the growing problems and the growing international expectations of the System. Inherent in the ad hoc nature of the response of the United Nations System in certain types of

emergencies is **lack of automaticity** in monitoring and responding to emergencies, which results in delays in the critical early stages of response.

For the time being, and given its relatively limited means, **UNDRO** concentrates on problems related to natural and sudden disasters, but its **mandate** also covers other emergencies such as those related to drought and civil conflict.

UNDRO carries out its mandate through programmes defined in the Organization's Medium Term Plans. The present **Programme** (period 1992-1997) is divided into three sub-programmes concerning:

- ☐ mobilization, direction, and coordination of international disaster relief, including advance arrangements (**operational preparedness**) for this
- ☐ promotion of **disaster mitigation**, including the provision of advisory services and technical assistance in disaster mitigation measures (prevention and preparedness),
- ☐ **information** exchange, awareness raising and transfer of knowledge on disaster-related matters.

UNDRO has most of the elements needed to play its full role as the United Nations System's specialized entity in disaster management/emergency response. This includes being the **"in-house"** agent to help the System as a whole play its part effectively and efficiently. **UNDRO** should play a catalytic and supportive role under the Secretary-General's leadership in such areas of system-wide need as: a **central focal point** in the UN for all types of emergencies, a standing Inter-Agency disaster management mechanism, agreed inter-agency emergency roles and operating procedures, **stand-by** UN emergency teams, a central emergency revolving fund, and common principles for emergency procurement.

UNDRO's overall goal for the 1990s is to provide **leadership**, vision and **knowhow** in promoting, applying and integrating the full range and complete continuum of disaster management activities worldwide that will take advantage of global experience and incorporate the most effective techniques. Working closely with the IDNDR Secretariat, **UNDRO** will seek to be in a position to be able to assume responsibility for these IDNDR activities and relationships which should be continued beyond the Decade. If the goal is to be achieved and **UNDRO's** potential is to be realized for the first time since its creation in 1971, four main problems must be resolved. They are:

- ☐ Insufficient **institutional capacity** to meet present responsibilities and expectations.
- ☐ Confused vertical and horizontal relationships and **lines of authority** and reporting between **UNDRO** and other parts of the UN System in disaster/emergency response.
- ☐ Divergent and often incorrect **perceptions** of **UNDRO** and a blurred public image.
- ☐ Critically insufficient **resources** to the tasks.

Reviewing **UNDRO's** twenty years of experience in international disaster management shows strengths to build on but also weaknesses to correct. Significant steps have already been taken to do both, to strengthen activities in **UNDRO's** Work Programme and to resolve the four major problems in the

above areas. Efforts will intensify in the framework of a strategic plan now being finalized. They will be made possible by a major investment of the overheads deducted from contributions made to UNDRO's Trust Fund for Relief Operations in connection with recent exceptional emergency situations.

II. INTRODUCTION

The discussions and analyses which have continued since the mid-60ies on the role which the United Nations System plays or could play in disaster management, including emergency response, have intensified recently. There is thus an opportunity for fresh, more efficient and effective action by the System as a whole, and by UNDRO in particular.

The present paper summarizes UNDRO's function and strategy in this context, drawing from UNDRO's experience over twenty years and from analysis of present requirements in international disaster management. The paper presents UNDRO's vision and goals in meeting its part of these and future requirements - goals which the Office is itself confident it can meet.

GA resolution 45/221 of 21 December 1980 requested the Secretary General "to make proposals to the Economic and Social Council for the strengthening of the capacity of the Office to fulfil its mandate, which are to be included in the proposed programme budget for the biennium". Last April, UNDRO submitted proposals for this purpose, and which were mostly reflected in Doc E/1991/121.

They are reiterated and amplified here in the context of the broader debate, and with particular reference to the observation on UNDRO made recently in the Secretary General's "review of the capacity, experience and coordination arrangements in the United Nations System for humanitarian assistance (A/46/58)". UNDRO's capacities need to be strengthened in order to provide efficient technical support services for both natural disasters and complex emergencies.

II. INTRODUCTION

A. Disaster Management

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The difference in destructiveness between hazardous events of comparable magnitudes in different but comparable environments shows that knowledge, techniques, procedures, and technologies do exist to "reduce" the impact of disasters at reasonable cost. The General Assembly's declaration (Resolution 44/238, 22 December 1990) of the International Decade for Natural Disaster Reduction (1990-2000) is an important statement of this fact.

Several concepts have formed around the practice of disaster management, especially but not exclusively in the developmental context, in particular:

- Disasters and Development are linked; disasters can restrain economic development; development can reduce, even prevent disasters; ill-planned development can increase disaster risk.
- Acts of force may also be acts of man; disasters are partly, or wholly due to man-made hazards, or to man ignoring or misperceiving natural hazards.
- After one disaster, relief is the status quo ante; will lead eventually to another disaster; if post-disaster assistance does not reduce vulnerability to future disasters, there will be disaster again.
- Disasters can be compounded or occur in chain reaction; one or more disastrous situations can occur simultaneously and/or cause others, thus creating a far more complex emergency.

¹ See UNDRO paper "Strengthening of the Office of the United Nations Disaster Relief Co-ordinator".

III. DISASTER MANAGEMENT

A. Disaster Management - Purpose and Concepts.

We live in a world of increasing populations, diminishing resources, and environmental deterioration. More people become poorer and, seeking livelihood, concentrate in larger numbers, in areas at risk from natural and technological hazards. In greater numbers too they become involved in, or are exposed to strife, often stemming from several interrelated causes.

The evidence and likelihood of increasing tolls from natural and other forms of disasters is recognized universally. In recent years, effort to resist and eventually to reverse this trend have been referred to as disaster management.

As awareness is raised of the interactive character of "natural" and "man-made" causes, and the notion of emergency humanitarian assistance is applied to disastrous situations irrespective of their origin(s), the concept of disaster management has come to embrace actions relating to catastrophic events in general.

Disaster Management is thus emerging as a distinct discipline aimed towards the prevention of disasters including "emergencies", or the reduction of their impact and coping with their consequences through a continuum of related steps - prevention, preparedness, relief, rehabilitation, reconstruction. Added to this thematic unity, is disaster management's inherent multi-sectorality, for rare are disasters which affect but one dimension of human activity.

The differences in destructiveness between hazardous events of comparable magnitudes in different but comparable environments shows that knowledge, techniques, procedures, and technologies do exist to "reduce" the impact of disasters at reasonable cost. The General Assembly's declaration (Resolution 44/236, 22 December 1989) of the International Decade for Natural Disaster Reduction (IDNDR) is an important statement of this fact.

Several concepts have formed around the practice of disaster management - especially but not only, in the developmental context. In particular:

- ☐ **Disasters and Development are linked;** disasters can restrain, even reverse development; development can reduce, even prevent disasters; ill-conceived development can increase disaster risk.
- ☐ **Acts of fate may also be acts of man;** disasters are partly, or wholly due to man creating hazards, or to man ignoring or improperly addressing hazards.
- ☐ **After one disaster, return to the status quo ante will lead eventually to another disaster;** if post-disaster assistance does not reduce vulnerability which led to the disaster, there will be disaster again.
- ☐ **Disasters can be compounded or occur in chain reaction;** one or more disastrous situation(s) can occur simultaneously and/or cause others, thus creating a far more "complex" emergency.

- ☐ There can be prediction or early warning of disasters; in most cases at least the location of potentially disastrous event can be predicted, in some cases also a time-frame. In most cases there can and should be early warning of the possibility of disaster.

B. A Glance at the Future.

Certain future trends may be defined. They are linked partly to the geo-political conditions, some of which have but recently been profoundly changed. The erosion of certain political alliances and systems, increased regional or national fragmentation, and a move towards "democratization" and market economies, are leading to new or newly aroused confrontations. Significant, but not new, are the growing gap between rich and poor, increased industrialization, increased population, deteriorating environment, and decreasing natural resources.

In disaster management terms, there is a trend towards greater vulnerability of more and poorer people increasingly concentrated in areas of greater risk from natural and technological hazards.

Aside from the greater impact which hazards can have on greater concentrations of people in areas of greater risk, there is a probability of certain hazards themselves increasing in number and intensity. Degradation of environmental conditions for example, will lead to larger or more frequent floods and landslides in some areas and diminishing croplands in others; increased industrialization will lead to more and greater technological accidents; if sea levels are raised and climates are affected by global warming, in the long term there will be more tropical storms striking new shores, and extensive flooding of land now close to sea level. Use can be expected of increasing stocks of more destructive weapons - even if "only" conventional - in local, national or regional conflicts.

It is probable that the world will see more frequent mega-disasters (disasters with victims in the tens of thousands, and costs in hundreds of millions of dollars, or in developing countries, "double digit" percentage impact on GNP).

Global awareness of the occurrence of such disasters will be high and immediate, for the speed and ubiquity of communication, will greatly strengthen the dissemination and impact of media reports.

In sum, there is reason to believe that the disaster management "problem" is likely to get worse before it gets better.

IV. THE ROLE UNDRO NOW PLAYS.

A. UNDRO's Functions: its Mandate, Programme and Activities.

UNDRO's functions in relation to 'natural disasters, and other disaster situations' were set out in its founding resolution (2816 XXVI of 14 December 1971). Some later resolutions² have added to these functions, but there has been little net change. GA Resolution 44/236 implicitly associated UNDRO with the full range of IDNDR activities, underscoring the close working relationship to exist between the Office and the Decade Secretariat. The 45th Session of the General Assembly, recently reaffirmed in Resolution 45/221 "that the Office of the United Nations Disaster Relief Co-ordinator is the focal point within the United Nations System for matters relating to disaster relief and disaster mitigation."

The functions of the Co-ordinator can be broken down into two connected areas: disaster relief mobilization and co-ordination, and promotion of disaster mitigation (prevention and preparedness).

With regard to disaster relief mobilization and co-ordination, the Co-ordinator, on behalf of the Secretary General, is authorized to:

- ☐ establish and maintain the closest co-operation with all organizations concerned and make all feasible advance arrangements with them for the purpose of insuring the most effective assistance,
- ☐ mobilize, direct and co-ordinate the relief activities of the various organizations of the United Nations system in response to a request for disaster assistance from a stricken state.
- ☐ co-ordinate United Nations assistance with assistance given by inter-governmental and non-governmental organizations, in particular the International Red Cross
- ☐ receive, on behalf of the Secretary-General, contributions offered to him for disaster relief assistance to be carried out by the United Nations, its agencies and programmes for particular emergency situations,
- ☐ assist the Government of the stricken country to assess its relief and other needs and to evaluate the priority of those needs, to disseminate that information to prospective donors and others concerned, and to serve as a clearing-house for assistance pledged or planned by all sources of external aid.

With regard to disaster mitigation, the Co-ordinator is to:

² Resolution 3243 (XXIX), Resolution 33/22, Resolution 35/228, Resolution 36/225, Resolution 36/259, Resolution 38/202, Resolution 39/207, Resolution 43/204, Resolution 45/221.

- ☐ promote the study, prevention, control and prediction of natural disasters, including the collection and dissemination of information concerning technological developments
- ☐ assist in providing advice to Governments on pre-disaster planning in association with relevant voluntary organizations, particularly with the League of Red Cross Societies, and to draw upon United Nations resources available for such purposes
- ☐ to acquire and disseminate information relevant to planning and co-ordinating disaster relief, including the improvement and establishment of stockpiles in disaster-prone areas, and to prepare suggestions to ensure the most effective use of available resources,
- ☐ to phase out relief operations under his aegis as the stricken country moves into the stage of rehabilitation and reconstruction, but to continue to interest himself, within the framework of his responsibilities for relief, in the activities of the United Agencies concerned with rehabilitation and reconstruction.

In complex disasters and emergencies of exceptional magnitude:

- ☐ ... following a request for disaster relief from a disaster stricken state and whenever required to deal effectively with complex disasters and emergencies of exceptional magnitude, the Secretary General or his representative, who would normally be the United Nations Disaster Relief co-ordinator, shall convene meetings of the concerned organizations of the United Nations System in order to develop a concerted relief programme and conduct ad hoc consultations with the heads or representatives of the agencies concerned with disaster relief questions (full text in GA Res 36/225 of 17 December 1981).

B. UNDR0's Activities In Three Programme Areas.

UNDR0 carries out its mandate through programmes defined in the Organization's Medium Term Plans. The Programme for the period 1992-1997 is divided into three Sub-programmes concerning:

- ☐ mobilization, direction, and coordination of international disaster relief, including advance arrangements (operational preparedness) for this
- ☐ promotion of disaster mitigation, including the provision of advisory services and technical assistance in disaster mitigation measures (prevention and preparedness),
- ☐ information exchange, awareness raising and transfer of knowledge on disaster-related matters.

Within these Sub-Programmes UNDR0 is carrying out our specific "demonstration" projects within the IDNDR programme of work, notably in the areas of information management, communications, training and risk reduction.

The following summarizes activities in the three Sub-Programme Areas:

"Operational Preparedness" of the UN System and of International Relief Mechanisms.

Acting on behalf of the Secretary-General:

- ☐ Provides policy guidance and based on "lessons learned" defines and advocates improved measures in UN System and international assistance community. Develops and promotes arrangements and protocols to expedite relief and facilitate communications.
- ☐ Prepares and make available international relief resource registers, of international emergency contact lists, of country disaster management profiles and statistics; develops mechanisms with international actors for information exchange and operational interaction, logistic and supply support readiness.
- ☐ Draws up, with UNDP, and in an inter-agency context, policies, guidelines and procedures for the United Nations Disaster Management Teams (UN-DMT's) in disaster mitigation, relief and rehabilitation/reconstruction. With UNDP, training of UN-DMT's, together with some governmental and other aid personnel.

Activities in International Disaster Relief.

Acting on behalf of the Secretary-General:

- ☐ At the international level, provides a framework for the mobilization and co-ordination of relief assistance by UN entities with that of bilateral donors, and inter/non-governmental organizations, and for the formulation of consolidated UN System statements of needs. At the country-level this is provided through the UNDP/UNDRO Resident Representative and the UN-DMT.
- ☐ Issues international appeals, reflecting a concerted UN relief programme where possible, and acts as an operational clearing house for information on damage/casualty assessments, needs and contributions of international relief assistance planned by donors and progress of relief operations.
- ☐ In the context of consolidated UN relief programmes and appeals, allocates to other agencies funds channelled through UNDRO following such appeals; if necessary, administers funds direct.
- ☐ Coordinates the identification of priority needs, normally through the UNDP/UNDRO Resident Representative and the UN-DMT on the basis of information from the Government and other competent bodies, and as requested in the context of specific inter-agency assessment missions.
- ☐ Assists national authorities and UN-DMT's in assessments and international reporting related to relief operations, and in local coordination of international relief assistance; assigns expert personnel for this, and to support UNDP/UNDRO Resident Representatives.
- ☐ As requested and funded, in specific operations, identifies, mobilizes, or furnishes specialized personnel and undertakes technical activities at country-level, e.g. information/data handling, communications, transport.

Provides up to US\$50,000 in immediate assistance per disaster. Releases and arranges deliveries from emergency stockpiles administered by UNDRO in Pisa. Organizes shared relief flights and reduced rate air transport.

Disaster Mitigation

- ☐ Provides a range of services to promote and support the establishment of permanent disaster mitigation measures. This includes early forecasting and warning, risk assessments, and guidance on disaster reduction strategies and their application.
- ☐ Provides disaster management inputs to UNDP country-programming exercises, formulates technical assistance projects for disaster mitigation, and advises on disaster-related considerations in different sectors, identifying specialized bodies and organizations most competent to provide particular forms of technical assistance.
- ☐ Furnishes technical assistance through specific consultancies, projects and programmes, funded by UNDRO's own funds, earmarked contributions, or UNDP SPR/IPF funding. UNDRO undertakes execution of UNDP-funded projects on sub-contract to DTCD or UNDP.OPS, and serves as Associated Agency in government executed projects.

Information Exchange, Transfer of knowledge and Awareness Raising

- ☐ UNDRO is a repository of specialized information. It facilitates the transfer of knowledge worldwide on more effective disaster management, and stimulates exchanges between interested bodies. It organizes and participates in specialized meetings and workshops. It interacts with international bodies to clarify and develop concepts and improve standards in disaster management.
- ☐ UNDRO offers specialized information, referral and limited research services at or from UNDRO by phone, fax, telex, postal/ electronic mail. This includes access to UNDRO data bases through UNINET (United Nations International Emergency Network). Publications are prepared or sponsored on disaster management - manuals, case studies, evaluations, reference and training materials, videos, periodic publication (UNDRO News), lecture series, internships. UNDRO maintains a specialized Reference Library and Data Bank.

Activities Relevant to all Three Programme Areas.

UNDRO, from its main office in Geneva and its office at UN Headquarters, New York, maintains routine contact with diplomatic missions in those two places. It interacts with entities responsible for disaster management and emergency assistance, training and research within UN, governmental, inter-governmental and non-governmental bodies worldwide. It liaises with technical institutions and organizations including hazard monitoring and warning bodies.

V. ORGANIZATIONAL PROFILE

A Small Office in the United Nations Secretariat-Headed by an Under Secretary-General

UNDRO, formally titled the "Office of the United Nations Disaster Relief Co-ordinator", is an integral part of the United Nations Secretariat. The Co-ordinator, an Under Secretary General, answers direct to the Secretary General. The Office is fully subject to the rules, regulations and procedures of the Secretariat, notably as they relate to the United Nations Office in Geneva (UNOG), where UNDRO is based. UNOG oversees, supports and regulates UNDRO's budgetary, financial and personnel administration.

Organization, Staff and Facilities.

UNDRO is organized into the Executive Office of the Co-ordinator, (including the Director and Deputy to the Co-ordinator) to which are attached the UN Headquarters Office and the liaison function with the IDNDR Secretariat, a Relief Co-ordination Branch, a Disaster Mitigation Branch, and an Administrative Support Unit. A number of separate entities - information systems support staff, Publications, Data Bank, Registry, Reference Library report to the Director. UNDRO now intends to consolidate these entities into structured units within a Disaster Information Branch. Professional and General Service staff normally total between fifty and sixty. UNDRO'S physical facilities include twenty offices loosely grouped among other UNOG offices at the Palais des Nations and a three room office at UN Headquarters New York. It maintains small offices at the Pisa Relief Supply Warehouse, and in Suva and Genoa in connection with regional technical assistance projects.

Field Presence

UNDRO has been represented in developing countries since 1973 by the UNDP Resident Representative. UNDP Guidelines for this were revised in 1979 and in 1983 and are about to be superseded by the provisions of a new and comprehensive UNDP/UNDRO Disaster Management Manual.

Most of the UNDP Resident Representatives have since been designated UN Resident Co-ordinators for Operational Activities in Development. They continue to represent UNDRO in the former capacity.

UNDRO staff travel to the field frequently for both relief and mitigation activities. In relief UNDRO Staff and relief specialists are usually titled "delegates" and work within the Office of the UNDP/UNDRO Resident Representative and to strengthen the UN-DMT.

The Iraq/Gulf crisis of 1990 initiated the role of SUNEM (Senior United Nations Emergency Manager), operating under the day-to-day supervision of the UN Resident Co-ordinator, but reporting to the UNDRO Co-ordinator.

Finance and Fund Raising (Extrabudgetary).

UNDRO is financed partly from the U.N. Regular Budget, partly from a Trust Fund for the Strengthening of UNDRO, and partly from a Trust Fund for Programme Support. Whereas contributions to the Strengthening Trust Fund are voluntary, income for this last Trust Fund is derived from statutory 3% and 13% overhead deductions respectively on contributions for specific relief operations, and for technical assistance in disaster preparedness and prevention.

In the current Biennium (1990-1991) UNDRO's Regular Budget appropriations are US\$ 7.4 million and Extra-Budgetary Appropriations are US\$ 4.2 million for a total of US\$ 11.6 million. Forty to fifty percent of UNDRO's staff costs, eighty percent of its communications costs and over ninety percent of its consultancy costs are paid from extra-budgetary resources.

For lack of staff, none are specifically assigned to fund-raising, nor is fund-raising a specific Office activity. It is done essentially by an annual letter from the Co-ordinator to permanent missions in Geneva, and through ad hoc interaction between senior staff and potential donors as part of their of their duties, usually on contributions needed for specific activities.

In the past two years, fund-raising strategies have been drawn up and implemented though the Executive Office of the Co-ordinator with respect to projects seen to be of critical importance; at present these are the UNDP/UNDRO Disaster Management Training Programme and the Information Management, Communications and Office Systems (IMCOS) Project.

Policy Formulation, Planning, Evaluation, Training.

For lack of staff resources, none have been specifically assigned to policy formulation and planning. Policy formulation and Planning are essentially done within the Secretariat norms and procedures by senior staff as part of their regular duties. Starting early in 1991, a collective effort has been initiated to develop more systematic policy formulation and strategic planning. This effort is being reinforced and institutionalized.

Similarly, staff have not been specifically assigned to training, though some had part-time responsibilities to help in limited internal training. In 1990, an internal Working Group on Training was established to insure ongoing assessment of training needs and problems, to propose policy and training, and to monitor implementation of training activities. The part-time staff function of a Training Manager has been defined and is filled. As a collective effort of the Office, the Working Group submitted a report concerning needs and outlining a training strategy. The Working Group on Training has been re-titled the Working Group on Staff and Organizational Development (WGSOD), as a further step towards institutionalizing internal training in UNDRO.

External, Inter-Agency, NGO, Press and Public Relations.

VI. UN CO-OPERATION

A. The Position

Again lack of staff has limited the formal attention which can be given to these important activities in Geneva, though a particular effort is made with respect to the press accredited to UNOG. These activities are undertaken by appropriate staff in the areas relating to their normal duties. In New York, for various reasons to do with the representational character of the Office there, a more active profile relative to its size has been possible possible, with good results.

Overseeing and Advisory Bodies

UNDRO's activities fall within the purview of ECOSOC. Its work is reviewed in the Second (Economic and Social) Committee of the General Assembly; its administration and budget in the Fifth Committee.

It submits a formal report on its activities to ECOSOC and the General Assembly every two years, and on specific subjects in the area of humanitarian/emergency assistance as assigned by the Secretary General.

UNDRO has no separate governing council or board. It has established and convenes a meeting every other year of Heads of of National Emergency Relief Services (NERS). It has established and periodically convenes Advisory Boards to its periodical, "UNDRO" News, and to its electronic mail and data base network, UNIENET (United Nations International Emergency Network).

VI. UN CO-ORDINATION

A. The Position of UNDR0.

As a world system oriented towards development and providing technical, social, economic and humanitarian assistance oriented towards development, and also as a political body, the United Nations is involved in disaster management. It provides technical assistance in prevention and preparedness. It undertakes mobilization, coordination, and provision of international relief supplies and services and of reconstruction/rehabilitation aid and expertise.

The scope and importance of disaster management, and the number and variety of actors worldwide (international and inter-governmental organizations, governments, NGO's including the Red Cross/Red Crescent) calls for the existence of an international body specialized on this subject. Disaster management is cross-sectoral and best addressed as a thematic unity.

UNDR0's establishment in 1971 was the United Nations' first structural manifestation of its increasing involvement in disaster management. There have since been set up a number of specific disaster/emergency entities and programmes in the specialized agencies and regional commissions. The United Nations System works in disaster response on the basis of specialized but related mandates, capacities, and structures and operating procedures.

UNDR0 is the United Nations Office whose mandate relates exclusively to disaster management - in its entire spectrum - and which is responsible on a continuing basis to the Secretary General. In disaster mitigation its focus is cross-sectoral policy, planning, organization and procedures.

The corresponding focal point at the country-level is the office of the UN Resident Co-ordinator/UNDP Resident Representative. The UN Disaster Management Team (UN-DMT) established under his/her responsibility serves to ensure concerted assistance at the country level in all aspects and phases of disaster management, to act as a country-level UN focal point and information service for the Government and the locally-represented international community, to ensure UN system preparedness at the country-level, and in the event of a "multi-sectoral" disaster to act in a concerted manner in support of national and international response.

Virtually the entire UN System has disaster management resources and activities - UNICEF, UNDP, UNEP, UNRWA, HABITAT, UNHCR, WFP, ILO, FAO, UNESCO, WHO, ITU, WMO, IMO, IAEA. Many of these have units specifically concerned with disaster/emergency management. Concise summaries of the roles and capacities of those with which UNDR0 regularly interacts are given in Annex D1 of the UNDP/UNDR0 Disaster Management Manual. The capacities, functions and roles of these, and of UNDR0 itself are not entirely constant from year to year, or often from emergency to emergency. UNDR0 has memoranda of understanding with almost all. There are other such memoranda between the agencies themselves. The UNDP/UNDR0 Task Force Report (A/43/731) has had important effects in developing joint training and field level guidelines.

At present roles and responsibilities of the UN System revolve around three types of emergencies, as distinguished in the Secretary General's report A/42/657 of 1987, endorsed by General Assembly decision 42/433:

Disaster situations "which (fall) clearly within the competence of one of the United Nations organizations or specialized agencies and for which that organization (is) primarily responsible.

Natural disasters and other disaster situations in which "aspects" fall outside "the specific mandate of a particular ... agency, involving more than one organization and necessitate the United Nations Disaster Relief Co-ordinator playing a co-ordinating role for the United Nations System as a whole".

"... in exceptional circumstances, Disaster and emergencies of such magnitude and complexity that special arrangements would be needed to co-ordinate, mobilize and deliver emergency relief."

The Secretary General has made various arrangements for this last category. These normally involve the designation of special or personal representatives or Co-ordinators, and of specific secretariat entities/individuals for monitoring and backstopping. In recent years, the Department for Special Political Questions, Regional Co-operation, Decolonization and Trusteeship has held the lead role for complex emergencies in Africa, the Office for Research and the Collection of Information, and the Director General for Development and International Economic co-operation have had ongoing responsibilities for informing the Secretary General on potential or existing disaster situations. As in the case of the UN's response to natural disaster, the UN System's field structure, in some cases reinforced, has been linked to a designated UN entity headquartered in New York or Geneva.

B. The Strengthening Needs Summarized.

Central Focal Point in the United Nations for All Types of Emergencies. While UNDRO is de facto recognized as a central UN focal point with an automatic mandate for sudden natural disasters, no comparable responsibility has been established for "complex" emergencies aside from those arising in Africa. The lack of automaticity in the response of the United Nations System in these emergencies, because of the nature of the co-ordination systems used, contribute to delays in the critical early stages of emergencies. There is a pressing need for a central focal point in the United Nations for all types of emergencies, especially with respect to the conduct of joint needs assessments, and to the preparation and issuance of consolidated appeals and related information.

System-wide Prediction and Early Warning. UN actors likely to be involved in emergencies need to receive warning of them as early as possible for "operational preparedness". Prediction and early warning is feasible for many aspects of most types of natural disasters and other emergency situations, including mass movements of populations. The procedures and means by which to collect, collate, analyze, produce and disseminate the necessary information to all concerned in the System, when and where needed, are yet to be established as a comprehensive mechanism - though many of the required elements of such a mechanism already exist independently inside and outside the System.

Standing Inter-Agency Emergency Management Mechanism. Recent experiences with and without such mechanisms have shown their value in effecting coordinated preparedness and response. There is need to establish at the senior management level a standing machinery for consultations in emergencies and for maintaining system-wide preparedness - which would in fact correspond to the ongoing inter-agency interaction expected from the country-level UN-DMT. Major actors outside the system such as the ICRC, the League of Red Cross and Red Crescent Societies and the International Organization for Migration need to be associated.

Agreed Inter-agency Emergency Operating Procedures. Disaster Management policies and procedures vary between UN organizations, and are reflected in respective internal instructions and manuals. There are points of commonality, but also gaps and duplications in areas where joint and complementary approaches are needed. These should be identified, and an inter-agency effort made to agree at least on a minimum set of joint standard operating procedures, building on the points of commonality and setting out the broad lines of their respective responsibilities and interaction.

Standby UN Emergency Teams There is recurrent and sometimes sudden need to increase the UN disaster management capacity in a disaster-stricken country. The UN system has staff, resources, experience and expertise for this, but the assets are often dispersed, and are not readily put in place as effective inter-agency teams, equipped, organized and ready for operation soon after arrival in-country. These can and should be constituted, with staff and resources identified beforehand, and within respective organizations kept on a stand-by basis, as part of the System's operational readiness.

Central Emergency Revolving Fund. There is need to establish a revolving central contingency fund for emergencies in order to ensure a rapid, coordinated and automatic response from the United Nations System the moment an emergency is declared. At present an effective response is limited at the early stages of emergency response by the length of time it takes for the United Nations to prepare appeals and for donors to pledge and actually disburse their contributions. In the interest of effective emergency coordination it is necessary to maintain this fund centrally.

Exceptional Standards for Emergency Procurement. In many instances the United Nations rules and procedures for the procurement of goods and services, for transport and storage of emergency supplies are not geared sufficiently to emergency requirements. The exceptional standards for emergency procurement procedures would contribute significantly to a more rapid and coordinated response.

VII. FOUR MAJOR PROBLEMS AFFECTING UNDRO

In reviewing UNDRO's mandate (as built on over the years in successive General Assembly Resolutions), its present and past activities, its organizational profile, and the environments in which it operates, it is unlikely that the Office will realize its full potential unless four problems are squarely faced and resolved. They are:

- ☐ Insufficient institutional capacity to meet present and future responsibilities and expectations.
- ☐ Confused vertical and horizontal relationships and lines of authority between UNDRO and other parts of the UN System in disaster/emergency response.
- ☐ Divergent and often incorrect perceptions of UNDRO and a blurred public image.
- ☐ Critically insufficient resources to the tasks.

1. Institutional Capacity to Meet Responsibilities and Expectations.

As a body which addresses disaster management issues daily, UNDRO is the first to recognize that they call for more effective measures and better approaches than the Office can now take. UNDRO is looking at its institutional capacity carefully, for the Office's level of achievement does not do justice to the efforts of its staff.

Staff. That there is need to strengthen staff capacity is due partly to the fact that in the past professional abilities have not been developed systematically in function of respective responsibilities and career advancement. But it is mostly due to the fact that there are not enough staff, and that the expertise available internally is not strong or diverse enough in key areas. Certain important functions, notably in the areas of Policy and Planning, Financial Planning and Fund Raising, Information Management, Public and External Relations, are not reflected in the manning table and are thus only summarily covered as time allows. There is need for more specialized staff "in-house" or on-call who with strong disaster management backgrounds can act and speak authoritatively in field operations.

Internal organization and procedures. These too are being examined for they have tended to compartmentalize rather than unify efforts; undermining in particular the interaction needed between disaster relief and mitigation activities during and after disasters. The mechanisms and procedures by which to ensure institutional memory, and to maintain consistent approaches to problems and issues over time are receiving special attention for this fact is recognized by the staff as a whole and is a common preoccupation.

Information Management. A focus of attention internally is on the systems and processes by which UNDRO receives, handles and distributes information. UNDRO's small staff spends too much time and effort finding things out, and does not have enough well organized information to track performance and plan in consequence. Office systems, notably word processing, data-base man-

agement and communications are time-consuming to operate, and too often incompatible with each other, and with systems used outside UNDRO.

Critical Services. Being an integral part of the Secretariat relieves the Office of some financial and administrative functions it would otherwise have to undertake itself. However, the administrative, budgetary, and financial procedures of the Secretariat, and support services normally offered at UNOG can be constraints on UNDRO's need to act quickly and perform efficiently and effectively in emergency response and the provision of technical assistance - neither of these two corresponding to the usual Secretariat activities.

Technical Feedback. There is insufficient interaction and "feed back" at a technical policy and planning level between UNDRO and its disaster management constituency - in the donor community, those who furnish technical or relief assistance, and in "recipient" countries, those charged with national disaster management policy, planning and administration. The community is but partly present - other than in an essentially diplomatic and political dimension - at ECOSOC and the General Assembly. This is especially true of senior disaster managers in the "recipient" countries, who are key arbiters of UNDRO's effectiveness. UNDRO's meetings of National Emergency Relief Services help overcome this weakness, but the meetings have no formal advisory status, are bi-annual, and so far have been poorly attended by developing countries. This weakness has been partly recognized at the recent 4th NERS meeting, at which consideration was given to creating an advisory body of NERS representatives.³

Location. UNDRO is based in Geneva. This favours easy interaction with the many other UN and non-UN humanitarian organizations, and activities, with the diplomatic community "covering" them. The location is favourable with respect to a large number of "donor" governments and the EEC, and there is easy access to developing countries. But there is need to strengthen UNDRO's New York Office for greater "interaction" with, and presence in, the political dimension of emergencies - which, in the UN context, centers around UN Headquarters.

Field Presence. With its present resources UNDRO cannot provide the monitoring needed of disaster management issues in the field, especially with respect to the UN-DMT's condition of operational preparedness, and of their linkages to potential national and international relief actors. Here there is a need for technical assistance in "operational preparedness" regularly provided or on call. UNDRO's field presence is intermittent and on occasion inadequate. UNDRO staff are based in Geneva and have responsibilities there which must be followed - for some if only between field missions. Technical support to the UN-DMT's must be close at hand for both System preparedness and response.

Capacity to represent its own interests. As an Office of the Secretariat UNDRO cannot, or has not, undertaken certain tasks which are undertaken on its behalf, along with other Secretariat bodies, by designated entities. For example, UNDRO cannot execute UNDP-funded technical assistance projects in disaster management - these being the responsibility within the Secretariat of the Department for Technical Co-operation; UNDRO cannot represent itself in the UN System's Advisory Committee for the Co-ordination of Information Systems.

³ In a related matter, UNDRO is reviewed in the Second Committee (Economic and Social) of the General Assembly. This is logical in terms of certain limited aspects of UNDRO's work; but the bulk of it would be addressed more appropriately in the Third Committee (Social, Humanitarian and Cultural).

this being the responsibility of the Secretariat's Division of Computing Services in New York. The lack of representation of its highly specialized requirements are a serious impediment in the fulfillment of its functions.

2. Vertical and Horizontal Authority with Respect to the Secretary General, UN bodies and Agencies, UN Representatives in the Field.

In international disaster relief and emergency response UNDRO has suffered from poorly defined lines of authority and reporting to and from UNDRO.

Disaster relief and emergency response call for clearly defined operating procedures between clearly defined entities with clearly defined relationships. This is so for a localized emergencies, as it is so for international emergencies.

UNDRO is in Geneva. The source of UNDRO's information, the activities relating to the prioritizing of needs, disaster assessment interaction with the government and donors in-country, are in the hands of UNDRO in-country representative, the UNDP Resident Representative-cum Resident Co-ordinator. The authority of this person to coordinate the relief activities of the UN System rests on his acting on behalf of the UNDRO Co-ordinator, himself acting on behalf of the Secretary General. This authority dates back to 1973.

In actual practice his authority is largely recognized by the UN agencies concerned (and probably by most governments) as deriving from his role as UN Resident Co-ordinator of Operational Activities for Development - a title and function established at a later date - even though his domain is operational activities for development, not for relief or emergencies.

The strongest line of authority is obviously between the UNDP Administrator and the UNDP/UNDRO Resident Representative. A clear line of authority runs also from the Director General for Development and International Economic Co-operation, to UN Resident Co-ordinators. The weakest line runs from the Secretary General to UNDRO to the UNDP Resident Representatives.

At first sight this might appear to be purely theoretical problem. It is in fact fundamental, for it is on these lines of authority that standard operating procedures and relationships must rest.

In terms of lines of authority and reporting procedures from the field up, the OEOA exercise set clearly defined responsibilities. It underscored the need for precise, systematic and collective UN system efforts in emergency management - in particular with respect to assessment and information management. The OEOA experience showed it can be done in spite of difficulties.

There is also a pressing need to clarify UNDRO "horizontal" relationships with other UN actors in disaster management. These have and continue to prove workable in terms of the existing, relatively loose framework for co-ordinated UN System actions in disaster management. But in the tighter, more responsive and proactive approach now being sought, if UNDRO is to provide the necessary leadership services, then relationships and their implications in terms of respective commitments and responsibilities must be made clear between UNDRO and its sister organizations.

3. External Perceptions of UNDRO and its Public Image.

The disparate views, inside and outside of the UN, among officials and the general public, of what UNDRO is, what it does and what it can or should do, illustrate this problem.

At one extreme, in the eyes of some, UNDRO is a unit of the UN Secretariat with the associated limitations and constraints, and no field experience or authority. At the other extreme, UNDRO is seen as a specialized body within the UN System, organized, staffed and funded to embrace all the UN's efforts in disaster/emergency related issues as, for example, does UNEP for the environment.

The problem is serious, for the lack of a clear and generally recognized identity results in unmanageable pressures on UNDRO. These range between being ignored in areas in which it is competent, and being expected to perform in areas in which it may or may not be competent, but for which it does not have the resources, nor sometimes the mandate.

The image is troubled further by UNDRO's own acronym which refers to relief but ignores the Office's disaster mitigation activities. "UNDRO" thus misrepresents the Office's work and does injustice to the Office's important institutional linkage of disaster relief and mitigation.

4. Insufficient Resources.

UNDRO's resources, negligible at the outset, have not kept pace with the past twenty years' increased activities - inside and outside the UN system in disaster management and emergency response. They remain insufficient to the mandate, and the tasks given to UNDRO in successive resolutions, or asked of it by governments and specialized disaster management bodies.

Despite the repeated calls from the General Assembly to strengthen the Office, for the past fifteen years there has been no real increase in regular budget appropriations. And while extra-budgetary funds have increased (either from the strengthening Fund or from overheads) they have only covered the operating costs of the expanding day to day activities, but have not enabled investments to increase the quality of the office's performance.

The Effect of Resolving these Four Problems.

Resolving these four problems - which for the essential could be done in two to three years - should have the following effect:

1. Institutional Capacity to Meet Present and Future Responsibilities and Expectations.

UNDRO would be a stronger more coherent body, functioning along consistent lines towards clearly stated objectives in each of the three programme areas. Institutional knowledge and experience could be more easily tapped and used by the UN System. Greater effectiveness and efficiency would result at lower costs for staff time and effort invested.

2. Vertical and Horizontal authority with Respect to the Secretary General, UN Bodies and Agencies, and UN Representatives in the Field.

VIII. UNDRO'S

Clarifying the relationships, and the lines of authority and reporting, in particular making clear the specific responsibilities and obligations of the specialized entities of the UN System to UNDRO, and of UNDRO to these entities, would streamline critical management and information flow processes in emergencies. This is especially needed to remove ambiguities over the line of authority running from the Secretary General, through the Co-ordinator, to the UN Resident Co-ordinators and special representatives in the field, and to ensure that UNDRO can provide the leadership services needed in a more effective framework for concerted UN System emergency preparedness and response.

3. External Perceptions of UNDRO and its Public Image.

If external perceptions, within and outside the UN System, of UNDRO, its functions, capabilities, resources can become more homogeneous and accurate, expectations of the Office will be more realistic. UNDRO is more likely to be called on when needed for the expertise, resources, and facilities it is known to be able to provide satisfactorily.

4. Insufficient Resources.

If UNDRO can be assured routinely of the financial resources needed for its staff and its basic services, forward planning and projected use of resources can be done on a far sounder basis than is now possible. Funds now allocated from year to year to UNDRO's "strengthening" can be used for that purpose rather than as part of its normal operating budget.

UNDRO's overall goal for the 1980s is to provide leadership, vision and knowledge in planning, organizing and integrating the full range and complete spectrum of disaster management activities worldwide, that take advantage of global experience and integrate the most effective techniques.

UNDRO is working closely with the IDNDR Secretariat in Geneva to assist countries to take practical steps towards IDNDR goals, close and continuous interaction with the Secretariat to that by the end of the Decade, UNDRO will be a partner in assuming responsibility for those IDNDR activities and relationships which should ideally be continued beyond the Decade.

In order to achieve the following objectives:

1. To have the capacity to collect, analyze and disseminate information worldwide that is timely, accurate and useful to planners, to policy and decision makers, and to managers concerned with disasters.
2. To assist disaster-stricken countries at their request with the organization of national response and the effective and efficient mobilization, coordination and delivery of international aid.
3. To provide the required expertise, mechanisms and technology to the Secretary General to improve UN system response and serve as a motor for improvement of the international system, including the development of agreed inter-agency emergency operating procedures.
4. To be able to respond systematically to requests from countries, individuals and communities, and request assistance in the development and

VIII. UNDRO'S Strategy - Key Aspects.

The following summarizes how UNDRO intends to address the issues raised above, with respect to its three areas of work, to resolving the four major problems it confronts, and eventually, to meeting its overall goal. These measures are partly reflected in UNDRO's Work Plan for the coming biennium. They will be amplified and further elaborated in the strategic planning process now being institutionalized at UNDRO.

Implicit to the plan of action, and key to realizing any significant strengthening is the investment of the 3% overheads deducted from contributions made to UNDRO's Trust Fund for Relief Operations in connection with recent exceptional emergency situations. It is UNDRO's intention, explained to and supported by the 4th NERS meeting, to use this exceptional income of an estimated four million dollars, by investing two million dollars in each of the two years of the 1992/1993 biennium into the structural strengthening of the Office. The investment will be made notably in the areas of human resources, equipment and services for policy formulation, fund-raising, information management, training and public relations.

A. The Overall Goal and Objectives of UNDRO's Strategy.

UNDRO's overall goal for the 1990s is to provide leadership, vision and knowhow in promoting, applying and integrating the full range and complete continuum of disaster management activities worldwide, that take advantage of global experience and incorporate the most effective techniques.

UNDRO is working closely with the IDNDR Secretariat in Geneva to assist countries to take practical steps towards IDNDR goals; close and continued interaction with the Secretariat, so that by the end of the Decade, UNDRO will be in a position to assume responsibility for those IDNDR activities and relationships which should logically be continued beyond the Decade.

In reaching its goal, UNDRO will achieve the following objectives:

- ☐ To have the capacity to collect, analyze and disseminate information worldwide that is timely, accurate and useful to planners, to policy and decision makers, and to managers concerned with disasters.
- ☐ To assist disaster-stricken countries at their request with the organization of national response and the effective and efficient mobilisation, co-ordination and delivery of international aid.
- ☐ To provide the required expertise, mechanisms and techniques to the Secretary General to improve UN system response, and serve as a motor for preparedness of the international system, including the development of agreed inter-agency emergency operating procedures.
- ☐ To be able to respond systematically to requests from countries, individually and collectively, who request assistance in the development and

application of the sequence of activities required for anticipating and reducing the socio-economic impact of disasters.

- ☐ To promote consistently and facilitate, the integration of disaster management programmes with relevant disaster management planning and with the disaster related-activities of international, bilateral and NGO initiatives.
- ☐ To be an effective source of technical assistance and information to support national and international disaster management policies/programmes, particularly in institution building.

To achieve these objectives, UNDRO will:

- ☐ strengthen its performance in its three existing sub-programmes,
- ☐ give added emphasis to conceptual, organizational, and substantive contributions to the Secretary-General's ongoing efforts to strengthen the capacity of the UN System disaster/emergency management and humanitarian response.
- ☐ resolve the four major problems affecting the Office.

B. Strengthening Performance in the Three Programme Areas.

The activities described in UNDRO's programme for the forthcoming Medium Term Plan will be reinforced as described below.

Sub-Programme 1 - Disaster Relief

Operational Readiness.

UNDRO will establish and support a Standing UN Executive Committee for Disaster Management. The Committee will act to improve System-wide linkages, training and procedures for relief operations. It will clarify respective disaster management responsibilities, further UN System operational preparedness, including enhanced system-wide prediction and early warning, and develop registers of UN disaster-related resources and expertise. In the context of this Committee, UNDRO will press for and facilitate system-wide agreement on common and standard disaster management operating and reporting procedures, operational relationships, and disaster management guidelines on specific aspects which are relevant and of common concern to different UN bodies. A programme of work will be established to draw up precise recommendations to the Secretary General on the mechanisms and resources to be put in place, standby UN emergency teams, a central emergency revolving fund and standard emergency procurement procedures.

UNDRO will take the necessary steps with all concerned to develop the capacities of the UN-DMT's. The chief vehicle for this will be the UNDP/UNDRO Disaster Management Training Programme. There will be systematic monitoring of capacities and preparedness postures, especially in critical periods, such as before typhoon seasons, and assistance will be made available from UNDRO to strengthen the Teams as necessary.

International Disaster Relief.

UNDRO is significantly increasing its capacity to provide useful and timely information to international actors in emergency response, through the establishment and use of an Operations Center at UNDRO, closely linked to the UNDRO Office New York. Teams of trained staff will work in the center on a twenty-four hour basis if necessary; the Center will facilitate the inclusion in these teams of staff from other agencies when appropriate. Progressively, as the technical and procedural aspects can be worked out, key international actors will have access to real or near-real time information for respective operational decision making.

Within UNDRO, as more specialized staff are recruited, or made available through secondment, small field oriented teams will be established for rapid deployment to work as situations warrant - to strengthen UN-DMTP's, to reinforce specific government response needs, to meet technical requirements such data processing and communications, and in particular to act as a nucleus for standby UN Emergency Response Teams. Closer interaction between UNDRO's Disaster Relief and Mitigation Branches, is being brought about, notably in connection with emergency response to ensure that weaknesses identified in preparedness planning and response at the country-level, can be identified and proposed as areas for strengthening and possible technical assistance.

An internal Relief Co-ordination Manual is being prepared to set out and standardize UNDRO's policies, procedures, and resources in these and other related respects.

Sub-Programme 2 - Disaster Mitigation.

The activities set out in this area, aiming to stimulate wider investigation and understanding of the full range of potential hazards, are being carried out with special emphasis on the promotion of scenario studies that ensure properly linked sequences of measures (investigation, prescription, training). Increased efforts are being made, as resources allow, to capitalize on each new disaster to initiate or expand mitigation efforts in the light of lessons learned.

Increased emphasis is being given to including disaster management considerations within UNDP country programming exercises (as elaborated on within the UNDP/UNDRO Disaster Management Manual and in the Disaster Management Training Course). UNDRO is providing technical support to these exercises, to promote "disaster consciousness" among developmental planners, to investigate the disaster potential of major new developmental projects, and to help national authorities to integrate relevant international agency, bilateral and NGO efforts.

Sub-Programme Three - Disaster Information

In twenty years of existence UNDRO has accumulated, and continues to accumulate, large amounts of data and information on disaster management. This data and information is in UNDRO'S files, its Data Bank, its Reference Library, its own publications, directories and electronic data bases and in the personal experience of its staff and consultants working closely with the Office. It is a unique body of information, much of its organized specifically for use in disaster management, and offering "lessons learned" from past experience for policy, planning and operations inside and outside the UN System. Linked to this information resource is UNDRO's established international network of specialized disaster and emergency management entities in all constituencies - govern-

ment, inter-governmental, UN, non-governmental and academic, each with comparable specialized information in the related but respective spheres.

As described below, UNDRO is making considerable investment to strengthen through structural change, increased staff and office-wide computerization, its capacity to "manage" this specialized body of information, and reinforce its "networking" capacity. This will lead to significantly better information for the management of international disaster response (see above). It will develop considerably UNDRO's function, at the heart of its mandate, of being a global clearinghouse for disaster management information. The international disaster management community will find it possible, and easier and quicker than is now the case to get from UNDRO the disaster-related information it needs, or to be able to find out quickly how and where to obtain such information. UNDRO's existing data bases and registers are being reorganized and further developed in a structured computer-supported information system which will be accessible electronically worldwide. The broad lines of this effort were endorsed by the IDNDR'S Scientific Committee earlier this year.

UNIENET, the United Nations International Emergency Network, is a key facility for this. It is being enhanced to serve as a common tool for specialized communications (including early warning and rapid alert, and operational data) and information exchange between disaster managers and operational decision makers.

C. Resolving the Four Main Problems Affecting UNDRO.

1. Institutional Capacity to Meet Responsibilities and Expectations.

Staff

There is a pressing need for more experienced staff who can operate in field settings knowledgeably and with authority. Aside from ensuring that Secretariat recruitment procedures give these requirements the importance they deserve, UNDRO will continue its approaches to potential sponsors and specialized disaster management bodies to make such staff available on secondment.

The most urgent staffing requirements will be met, if necessary by covering posts from extra-budgetary resources in hand. At present these have been identified as two posts of Senior Planning and External Relations Officer and of Chief Disaster Information Branch, four posts in public information, training, in the Relief Coordination Branch and in the New York office, one post of Chief, Information Research, Collection and Control Unit), and three general service posts. In addition the post of Chief, Information Management Communications and Office Systems Unit should be upgraded.

Internal UNDRO Training

Internal training is being institutionalized. Detailed training standards are being set on training time and resources to be spent on categories of staff, areas of work, and aspects requiring specialized knowledge. UNDRO's internal training programme will "cross-fertilize" with the UNDP/UNDRO Disaster Management Training Programme (UN-DMTP). Interconnected training activities will aim at

strengthening institutional memory, developing a body of trainers, encouraging self-directed learning, establishing an UNDRO training resource center, sharpening management and personal effectiveness skills, reaching better understanding of internal UNDRO issues and procedures, and increasing professionalism in disaster management. Finally, and most importantly, practical experience will be stressed as a chief means of raising personal and institutional capacity.

Information and Information Management

There will be significant enhancement of UNDRO's Information Management, Communications and Office Systems (IMCOS). This will be undertaken through a tightly managed project scheduled to start in January 1992; the preparatory steps and planning for the project has been largely completed. It will lead to a central and sufficiently staffed and skilled IMCOS Unit to support the Office, to UNDRO staff in Geneva and New York being equipped, trained and operating in a common computer network, to significantly better information for the management of international disaster response, and to a worldwide electronic dimension to UNDRO's disaster information clearinghouse function.

A start has been made in rationalizing and grouping the staff and entities most directly concerned. An IMCOS Unit has been set up to conceptualize, develop, support, maintain and co-ordinate UNDRO's internal and external information systems. An Information Research, Collection and Control Unit (IRCC) is being established to capitalize on the complementarity of UNDRO's Data Bank, Reference Library, and Registry. Along with UNDRO's Information and Publications Unit, the IMCOS and IRCC Units will come together in a Disaster Information Management Branch, which will contribute to information-related policy decisions, planning and activities through the office and to interact externally with counterpart entities.

Strategic Planning, Financial Planning, External Relations

The Executive Office of the Co-ordinator will be strengthened with the addition of a senior staff member, responsible full-time for support to key but now weak areas of planning, fund-raising, and external relations.

An UNDRO Strategic Plan will be drawn up and maintained by an office-wide team under the responsibility of the above cited senior staff. The Plan will be used as the basis for the required periodic inputs to Secretariat bi-annual planning, and medium term budgeting exercises.

The staff member will also be responsible for medium and long term financial planning in function of needs defined in the Strategic Plan. He will review these in terms of appropriations envisaged from the Regular Budget, so that clear and comprehensive statements can be made to donors on the rationale and need for complementary voluntary contributions. He will work closely with the Administrative and Financial Support Unit to ensure that financial reports can be made in the formats and with the frequency required by different donors.

The staff member will reinforce the external relations capacity of the Office as a whole, in particular to sustain co-operation with NGO's.

Physical Facilities

Efforts will be continued on a priority basis to rationalize UNDRO's physical layout in Geneva and obtain the necessary space (in particular for the Oper-

ations Center) so that these factors do not constitute constraints to effectiveness and efficiency. In particular arrangements will be made with UNOG to bring all of UNDRO staff and facilities together in a single area of the building.

Field Presence

A stronger field presence will be developed through the progressive establishment of regional UNDRO Disaster Management Technical Assistants. The Technical Assistants, would be based at appropriate regional entities such as the UN Regional Commissions, Regional Offices of sister agencies, or at appropriate Collaborating Centers (of which UNDRO has three). They would be available to provide technical support within the regions in UNDRO's disaster mitigation and relief activities; in particular they would be on call to UN-DMT's to help them meet the standards or preparedness required.

Interaction with UNDRO's Constituency

For medium and long term policy formulation and planning, UNDRO will seek to strengthen interaction with and "feedback" from its disaster management constituency on the Office's technical disaster management activities. It will strive to do this by formalizing an advisory relationship with officials of National Emergency Relief Services NERS. The involvement of senior disaster management officials from developing countries will be sought actively.

2. Vertical and Horizontal Authority with Respect to the Secretary General, UN bodies and Agencies, UN Representatives in the Field.

UNDRO is counting on having this problem eliminated as one of the results of the current high level reviews and discussions on the United Nations and disaster management and emergency response, and in the context of the consequently strengthened inter-agency measures and mechanisms, which the Office will support and help develop.

3. External Perceptions of UNDRO and its Public Image.

The question of UNDRO's public image will be examined carefully with the aim of clarifying what UNDRO does, and what it does not do, thus helping to make outside perceptions and expectations of the Office more accurate and positive. A strategy will be defined to do this, with the help of the Department of Public Information. The effort will be undertaken by a reinforced Publications and Information Unit.

UNDRO's acronym will be reviewed and revised to reflect the Office's role accurately. This can probably be accomplished by adding an R - for Reduction (United Nations Disaster Reduction and Relief Office), thus at once reflecting its disaster mitigation work, and reinforcing the link to the International Decade for Natural Disaster Reduction.

4. Insufficient Resources.

As repeated calls from the General Assembly for strengthening of UNDRO have not resulted in either increases in Appropriations for the Regular Budget, nor in significant voluntary contributions to UNDRO's Trust Fund for Strengthening, UNDRO will increase and formalize its fund-raising activities. (Because of the very nature of this field, financial and human resources for a wide variety of disaster-related initiatives are available from a wide variety of Governmental, inter/non-governmental, private, foundation, philanthropic sources; commercial

enterprises can capitalize on the visibility of their contributions to such initiatives.) In particular, UNDRO will corollate its forward financial planning, over and above expected regular budget appropriations, so that comprehensive and fully costed proposals can be put to potential donors to ensure that ongoing costs are covered from multi-year extra-budgetary contributions announced in advance.

Twenty years ago, international experience with a succession of large and sudden natural disasters and "other disaster situations", and collective concern to meet humanitarian needs quickly and effectively led Member States to create UNDRO. In the past twenty years there have again been a succession of such disasters and "situations". UNDRO, along with much of the UN System, has played a part in virtually all of these and in countless others which do not reach international headlines. The Office, and its sister organizations have a body of experience which was not available to Member States in 1971.

For its part UNDRO, faced with the probability of another twenty years and more, of large and sudden natural disasters and of "other disaster situations" has assessed its performance and its own strengths and weaknesses. Stimulated by the IDNDR, guided by a still valid mandate, and stronger for a renewed sense of direction and purpose, UNDRO is building on its experience to be an effective mechanism to support the Secretary General and Member States in strengthening disaster management in the UN System and, in particular its emergency preparedness and response capacity.